ridiculous distance stipulation for concessional travel by train; this began in the British days, but made no sense today. In addition, as a landmark achievement, we were able to get the government's approval for chartered civilian flights from Leh and Partapur to Delhi and from Imphal to Kolkata. The weekly air force courier flights from Guwahati to Delhi continue to operate as well. These leave travel concessions benefited all ranks immensely and helped to raise their morale and motivation level. As far as the military special trains were concerned, we were able to induct new air-conditioned first- and second-class bogies as also proper kitchen cars. This was a great milestone and resulted in a quantum jump in the quality of train journeys as compared to military special trains of the past era, as described in Part II.

Many of us joined the army for the lure of action, adventure, appeal of serving the country and the love of uniform. Very few armies are engaged in fighting insurgency and terrorism or are deployed in guarding their borders in such large numbers as ours. Therefore, those of us who are in an operational area, which is approximately 30 per cent of the army, adorn the combat dress most of the time. In our nation, despite the law forbidding use of army uniform or accoutrements by people not entitled to wear it, there has been a proliferation of similar-looking uniforms and what is worse, by personnel from civilian security companies. The combat dress was introduced in the 1980s, and sad to say, also proliferated to a ridiculous extent. Different patterns and colours of camouflage dresses began to appear every day. Presuming that the fabric used for the army uniforms was very robust, its misuse as suitcase covers or on seats in buses or holdalls became commonplace! Since the officers have to buy their uniforms they purchase the cloth available from the local markets and get their uniforms or camouflage dresses tailored. So, no two officers were dressed alike or wore the same disruptive pattern dress and accoutrements. To say that we could be mistaken as army officers from different countries wouldn't be an exaggeration! Though the soldiers were issued with government-supplied combat dresses, the quality was poor and the colour faded very fast.